

Criteria 1: The packages

Mandriva as usual comes on a gigantic 4.4GB DVD image, filled up to the brim with software. The inclusion of every possible software package imaginable means you won't have to reach for your Internet connection in any but the most exotic of conditions. openSUSE is another DVD, albeit a bit smaller at 4.2 GB. It does not include as much software, but has something called 'Installation From Images'—actual disk images in which patterns of software are pre-installed from the RPMs and don't have to be installed manually—and this speeds up installs considerably. Ubuntu and Kubuntu are LiveCDs, each weighing in at 699 MB, and although the smallest download of the lot, it's unusable without an Internet connection because additional software needs to be downloaded from the Net before you can work on the OS.

Judgement: Unjudgeable. All of them are unique. openSUSE has a good blend of software on DVD, Ubuntu has an uber-small download size, and Mandriva includes everything but the kitchen sink on the DVD. It's your personal taste.

Criteria 2: Installation experience

In Ubuntu, the Ubiquity installer seems to improve drastically, release by release. Apart from being more stable, it now has even more polish. A slideshow during the set-up phase (Figure 8) actually enlightens us about the practical features of the operating system rather than brag about how this particular OS is the best of the lot (as openSUSE does) or advertise other products by the company (as Mandriva does). Out at the Kubuntu stable, the installer is one H-U-G-E surprise, with such a completely redesigned minimalist yet pretty UI (Figure 9) that you'll actually want to stare at it rather than do anything on it. I personally think this actually compares with the likes of the Windows 7 installer.

Over at Mandriva's stable, it's again the kitchen sink installer, and this time they haven't even changed the UI colours or theme (Figure 10). As a result, like the rest of the system, this looks ugly. There is a lot to configure in the installer, including installing everything minus the server tools, LXDE and XFCE, and about 30 MB worth of updates; so it took more than an hour to complete. Sure, if you choose to install only KDE4 and no updates, you can finish it in 15 minutes. But anything more and you are done for.

openSUSE is a very pleasant experience. The installer is darn pretty (Figure 11) and does as much as the Mandriva installer can do, but in a much better and more understandable way. The layout of the installer—presenting the installer pages as rich pages rather than dialog boxes—radiates charm. The 'Installation From Images' feature speeds up installation. And if the installer finds an Internet connection during

installation, it automatically installs Adobe Flash and Microsoft TTF fonts. It can't install the codecs, though, because those stay in the third-party Packman and VLC Repos. It's one of the best-designed professional installers I have ever seen.

The Good	openSUSE 11.2, Kubuntu 9.10
The Bad	Ubuntu 9.10
The Ugly	Mandriva 2010. And it really is ugly

Criteria 3: Software

Mandriva fans rejoice! I have nothing more to say. Want KDE4? GNOME? LXDE? XFCE? Games? Servers? HPC Clusters? Databases? Three office suites? All it took me was 10 minutes to download the Nvidia drivers, and I was playing *Battle For Wesnoth* on Mandriva before I knew what I was doing.

All three have Kernel 2.6.31, so I can't pull anything here.

The Good	Mandriva 2010
The Bad	openSUSE 11.2
The Ugly	Ubuntu 9.10

Criteria 4: Looks, GNOME and KDE4 implementations

Does it even look like openSUSE has any competition here? Had they included the sub-pixel rendering patches for freetype, XFT and Cairo, openSUSE with its lime green KDE4 (Figure 4) and dark suede green GNOME (Figure 5 and Figure 12) would have scored a perfect 10 in the looks department. Even without them, nobody comes even close. This has the best KDE4 implementation around.

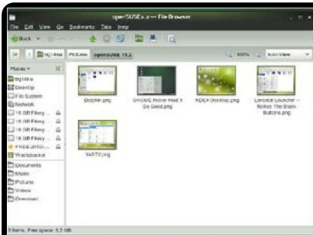


Figure 12: Up, close and personal with the Sonar theme using Nautilus